the Wisconsin Supreme Court should have forced the Northpointe company to reveal how the COMPAS algorithm decided that Eric Loomis was a high-risk person. But if the full data was disclosed, could either Loomis or the court have made sense of it?

It's not just that we need to take numerous data points into account. Perhaps most important, we cannot understand the way the algorithms find patterns in the data and decide on the allocation of points. Even if we know that a banking algorithm subtracts a certain number of points from people who allow their smartphone batteries to go below 25 per cent, how can we evaluate whether that's fair? The algorithm wasn't fed this rule by a human engineer; it reached that conclusion by discovering a pattern in millions of previous loan applications. Can an individual human client go over all that data and assess whether that pattern is indeed reliable and unbiased?[43]

There is, however, a silver lining to this cloud of numbers. While individual laypersons may be unable to vet complex algorithms, a team of experts getting help from their own AI sidekicks can potentially assess the fairness of algorithmic decisions even more reliably than anyone can assess the fairness of human decisions. After all, while human decisions may seem to rely on just those few data points we are conscious of, in fact our decisions are *subconsciously* influenced by thousands of additional data points. Being unaware of these subconscious processes, when we deliberate on our decisions or explain them, we often engage in post hoc single-point rationalisations for what really happens as billions of neurons interact inside our brain.[44] Accordingly, if a human judge sentences us to six years in prison, how can we – or indeed the judge – be sure that the decision was shaped only by fair considerations and not by a subconscious racial bias or by the fact that the judge was hungry?[45]

In the case of flesh-and-blood judges, the problem cannot be solved, at least not with our current knowledge of biology. In contrast, when an algorithm makes a decision, we can in principle know every one of the algorithm's many considerations and the exact weight given to each. Thus several expert teams – ranging from the US Department of Justice to the non-profit newsroom ProPublica – have picked apart the COMPAS algorithm in order to assess its potential biases.[46] Such teams can harness not only the collective effort of many humans but also the power of